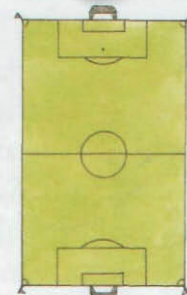


FOOTBALL



THE VARIOUS FORMS OF FOOTBALL are among the most popular sports to play and watch. Association football, or soccer, is played in almost every country by men and women. Rugby games are less widespread, but the new professional rugby union is becoming increasingly international. American football, although watched worldwide on television, is played little outside the United States. Other "national" games include Australian football, played chiefly in the state of Victoria, and Gaelic football, an Irish game.

Soccer ball



Soccer pitch

Soccer

Soccer is a kicking game played 11-a-side. The goalkeeper is the only person allowed to handle the ball. The object is to propel the ball into the opposition's goal with a foot or the head. A game lasts 90 minutes, with a 15-minute interval plus, in some knock-out competitions, an extra 15 minutes each way.

World Cup

The soccer World Cup is as popular as the Olympics. About 170 countries enter competitions to qualify for the 32 places in the finals, which take place every four years.



Pelé

Brazilian soccer star Pelé (b. 1940) won universal acclaim when he inspired Brazil to win the World Cup for the first time in 1958. His performances in Brazil's 1970 triumph have gone down in soccer folklore. In a first-class career he scored 1,281 goals.



Women's soccer

In 1991, the first women's soccer World Cup was held, and women's soccer was accepted as an Olympic sport in 1996. In many countries, girls now begin playing soccer at school.



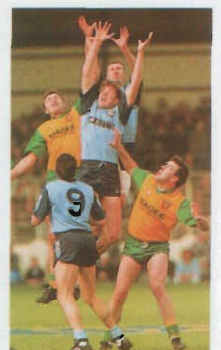
Australian football

Australian football is played 18-a-side on a huge oval field. Players kick, catch, and run with the ball which must be grounded every 10 m (33 ft). A goal, kicked between the inner posts, is worth six points; a behind, kicked inside the outer posts, scores one point.



Gaelic football

This is played 15-a-side with a round ball. It is a cross between soccer and Australian football. The ball may be kicked, fisted, and passed hand-to-hand. Points are scored by kicking the ball between the posts, under the bar for three points, over for one point.



American football

A handling game, American football is played 11-a-side with limitless substitution from 40 players or more. It is divided into short bursts of action as the attacking team advances in a series of "downs". Points are awarded chiefly for touchdowns and field goals.



American football



American football field

Equipment

To withstand the crunching tackles and blocks, players wear extensive protective padding under their uniform, the amount and type depending on their role. Players wear a number from 1 to 99 to identify them.

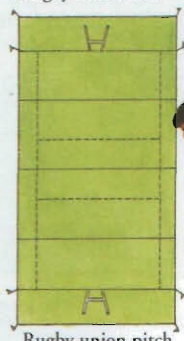


Rugby

The rugby codes are rugby union and rugby league. They are handling games featuring running, hand-to-hand passing, tackling, and kicking. Points are scored for a try – touching the ball down over the opposition goal line, or a goal – kicking the ball over the cross bar and between the posts. The two codes have a slightly different ball and pitch.



Rugby union ball



Rugby union pitch



Rugby union

This is played 15-a-side with eight forwards, two halfbacks, four three-quarters, and one full-back. It features scrums (shown here), line-outs to restart play, and tactical kicking. Tries score five points and conversions two points.

Rugby league

Rugby league is played 13-a-side. A tackled player may rise and play the ball with his foot. After six successive tackles, a team must give up the ball to the other team. Tries score four points, goals one or two.

FIND OUT
MORE

BALL
GAMES

OLYMPIC
GAMES

TENNIS AND OTHER
RACKET SPORTS

SPORT